and the revenue deficit is expected to cross Rs 2 lakh crore. The new government will have to face this challenge. A progressive state like Maharashtra may be regressing when it comes to the state of its finances."

A WINNING STRATEGY

Oblivious to such misgivings, leaders from the ruling combine assert that Ladki Bahin and other schemes will help them counter the MVA challenge in polls. This has set off a competition among the ruling allies to claim credit for the scheme. Though Shinde is seen as having stolen a march over his coalition partners by naming it after him, some Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leaders have put up banners crediting it to Ajit Pawar, omitting reference to the CM in the scheme's name. Shiv Sena ministers raised objections to this during a recent state cabinet meeting. Interestingly, Opposition leaders have also hurried to win favour with the electorate, setting up camps to enrol beneficiaries.

"This scheme will be a game-changer. The women are associating with it... it will impact the assembly election results," says Shiv Sena leader Sanjay Nirupam. He highlights how such schemes had helped the BJP in MP and the Aam Aadmi Party in Delhi. A senior Maratha community leader agrees. He says the government schemes, especially Ladki Bahin, are expected to have an impact in regions like Vidarbha and Marathwada, which faced agrarian distress and have low disposable incomes. It may reduce the extent of anger among the Marathas in Marathwada against the BJP and deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis. In the recent general election, a large section of the Maratha voters, along with Dalits and tribals, coalesced around the MVA, helping the Opposition win seven of the eight seats in Marathwada.

A senior NCP leader claims a reduction in the anti-incumbency sentiment—and attributes it to the direct benefit transfers. An opposition Congress leader disagrees: "There are precedents of incumbents losing despite populist measures. We lost power in Rajasthan despite such schemes. In Karnataka, our five guarantees did not yield substantial dividends in the LS polls. The erstwhile UPA government lost despite the [National] Food Security Act [2013]." His party colleague from north Maharashtra suggests that highlighting localised issues such as the drop in onion prices and the larger narrative around the engineered split in the Shiv Sena and NCP could counteract any possible pro-incumbency advantage. However, a senior Shiv Sena (UBT) leader admits that these schemes, especially Ladki Bahin, would influence women voters to an extent. "By the time the assembly election is announced, beneficiaries would have got multiple instalments and benefits.... We can only raise doubts about whether the scheme will continue even after the polls. Moreover, a substantial number of beneficiaries are Muslims and Dalits, and they may be averse to voting for the Mahayuti even after availing of these doles," he explains. A senior BJP MLA counters this argument. "At least the extent of anti-incumbency will decline. During the Lok Sabha polls, Dalits and Muslims turned out in large numbers just to vote against the BJP. We will gain if this is not repeated." However, there is fear even within the government that these populist schemes may lead to expenditure on other crucial projects taking a hit. "Often, old welfare schemes are starved of funds at the cost of the newer ones. For instance, there is a need to scale up the Shivbhojan scheme (a thali meal at Rs 10) from the present 200,000 thalis per day to 500,000. But this has not been done due to a resource crunch," notes a senior minister.

₹90,000 CRORE
The financial burden of the welfare schemes announced this year. The flagship Ladki Bahin Yojana alone is expected to cost Rs 46,000 crore

₹6.12 LAKH CRORE
The budget outlay this year. At Rs 1.10 lakh crore, the fiscal deficit is within the mandated 3% currently but may exceed it

THERE IS CONCERN EVEN WITHIN THE GOVERNMENT THAT THESE POPULIST SCHEMES WILL COME AT THE COST OF THE FUNDING FOR OTHER PROJECTS

BUT IS IT WELFARE?

CM Shinde is keen to present himself as a leader focused on welfare, according to a Shiv Sena source. "Unlike most of his predecessors who have been largely political figures, Shinde wants to launch his own brand of [welfare] politics with a focus on the poor, women and development," he says. "Ideological conviction matters more for men while women have to fight their daily battles... in a survey of around 40,000 women, Shinde's approval rating is 74 per cent."

Others dismiss these initiatives as nothing more than political expediency rather than any greater common good. "There is no Ladki Bahin or Ladka Bhau, only Ladki Khurchi, or favourite chair. These schemes are nothing but ridiculous electoral gimmicks ahead of the assembly election," says Anish Gawande, national spokesperson, NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar). Beneficiaries point to how the monthly dole of Rs 1,500 is a "cruel joke" on families whose budgets have gone haywire "because of the triple threat of this triple-engine sarkar: inflation, unemployment and corruption." Similarly, Atul Londhe Patil, general secretary and chief spokesperson of the state Congress, alleges that "these schemes offer little guarantee of longevity and this dole is minuscule compared to the rising inflation". A veteran social activist from the state's tribal belt levels an even graver charge when he says the government is doing little to alleviate poverty per se. "The focus is on political opportunism and the funds meant for weaker sections are being diverted," he says. Will voters see through it? ■